Grito de Vieques and Commonwealth

By Aya de Leon and Tato Laviera

INTRODUCTION

Vieques, a small island that is part of Puerto Rico, has been under U.S. Military occupation since 1941. During that time, the island and its occupants have been subjected to continuous U.S. military exercises with live ammunition, including radioactive material. In April 1999, two bombs missed their target and killed David Sanes-Rodriguez, a civilian security guard. This incident touched off the most recent wave of resistance in Vieques and throughout the Puerto Rican community at large. Grito de Vieques or "My Name is Vieques" by Aya de Leon

Grito de Vieques

My name is Vieques.

I am a Puerto Rican girl.

My stepfather is the United States.

He comes into my room at night to do his business.

4NG Fanatics

My name is Vieques.

I used to dream that Spain, my real father, would come back and rescue me.

But he's gone for good.

I have only the faint and echoing voices of Africana and Taina ancestors telling me that I can survive this.

My name is Vieques.

When my body started to change,

my stepfather dressed me in a clingy, itchy dress.

"Smile," he told me. "Smile at the nice foreign military man," and pushed me toward him.

The military man was not nice.

His skin was pasty. His breath smelled.

I couldn't understand his language.

He came into my room and did his business.

My name is Vieques.

Sometimes my stepfather sells me to whole groups.

He calls them allied forces.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I fought back the best I could with chains and live
bodies and fishing boats.
It happened anyway.

My name is Vieques.
I am still fighting back.
I am bigger and stronger now.
I have put a church, an encampment,
a struggle up at my bedroom door.
My stepfather can't get in.
He has not been able to do his business for months now,
longer than I ever dreamed.

My name is Vieques.
Without the shock of constant bombardment,
the numbness is subsiding.

I look at my body and see the devastation.
Lagoons, like self-esteem, have dried up to nothingness.
My womb is wilting with radiation
from illegally used uranium ammunition.

4NG Fanatics

Where my skin was once lush and soft, I am scarred.
Old tanks, like cigarette burns, dot my flesh.
Unexploded bombs, like memories, may detonate in the
future
when chosen lovers touch me in the wrong spot
or without warning.

My name is Vieques.
The numbness is subsiding.
Tender shoots of grass push up toward the sky.
A lizard sneaks back to sun itself on a chunk of shrapnel.
A butterfly alights on a rusted-out jet.
Fish slowly make their way back toward my shores,
no longer reverberating with shockwaves of violation.
My name is Vieques.
This is my body.
It may be worth eighty million dollars a year to you,
Yanqui,
but it is priceless to me.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

My door is barred.

I have burned the clingy, itchy dress.

The encampment grows stronger.

The lizards, the grass, the fish, the butterflies stand

with me.

I'll never be the same,

but I'll never be yours again to do your dirty business.

My name is Vieques

and I will be free.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Aya de Leon
Book: Word Warriors
ISBN: 978-1580052214
Publisher: Seal Press
Date (Month/Year): Oct 2007

4NG Fanatics

TRANSITION

Ever since the United States invaded Puerto Rico in 1898 and then was handed the island by Spain as part of the settlement for the Spanish-American War, the island's people — American citizens since 1917 — have been continuously put in situations where they are simultaneously auditioning for statehood, agitating for independence, and making the very best of living in limbo. Tato Laviera calls this limbo the "commonwealth stage of life." Commonwealth by Tato Laviera.

Commonwealth

no, not yet, no, not yet

i will not proclaim myself,

a total child of any land,

i'm still in the commonwealth

stage of my life, wondering

what to decide, what to conclude,

what to declare myself.

i'm still in the commonwealth

stage of my life, not knowing

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

which ideology to select.

i'm still in the commonwealth

stage of my life, all of us

caught in a web of suspension,

light-years away from the indians'

peaceful enclaves.

i'm still in the commonwealth

stage of my life, observing the many integrated experiences

we took everything

and became everybody else.

i'm still in the commonwealth

stage of my life, but there's

not enough hatred in our hearts

to kill each other or to draw

blood for too long, ours

is a mental search

4NG Fanatics

carved through a mainstream of options

but yet, somewhere

in the commonwealth, we all yearn

to feel our strengths,

to show our ultimate,

to find common wealth among us,

to close our eyes,

to find the total silence, silencio, silence,

to find ... not one thing that unites us,

even in silence we are still

in the commonwealth stage of our lives,

so let's touch hands, friends and foes,

and stay together to hear each other's

sounds just for one moment, let's stay

tucked together, and maybe then, less

options, maybe then, hope.

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Tato Laviera
Book: AmeRican
ISBN: 978-1558853959
Publisher: Arte Publico Pr
Date (Month/Year): March 2003

AWARD HISTORY

CO State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY